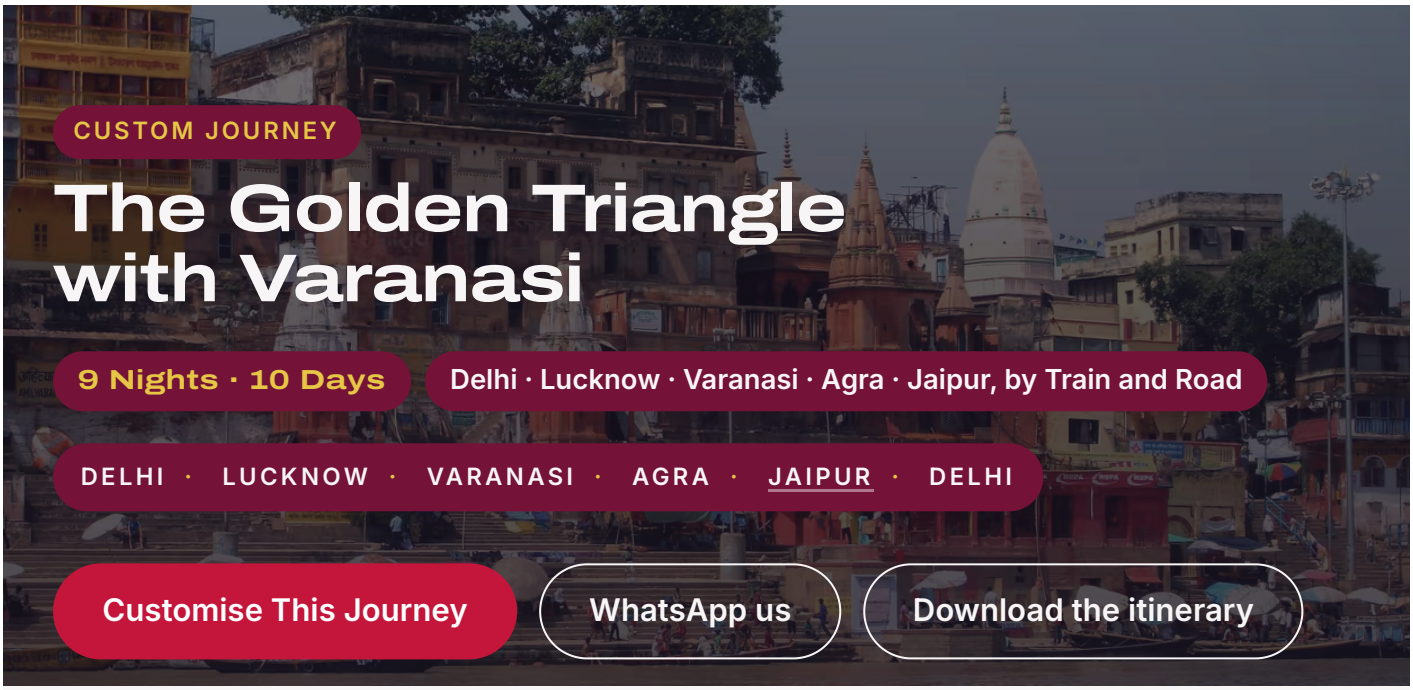
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DURATION
9 Nights · 10 Days

ROUTE
Delhi return

PACE
Active

BEST SEASON
October to March

IDEAL FOR
Couples, Solo, First-Timers

The Golden Triangle is the best week-long introduction to northern India. Add Varanasi and it becomes something else: a journey that reaches the Ganges, one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world, and the spiritual centre of Hinduism — and gets there by train, which is how the country still mostly travels.

Ten days, then: Delhi, Lucknow's Nawabi courtliness, two nights and a dawn boat ride in Varanasi, and then Agra and Jaipur on the way back. Two of the nights are spent on the railway, in reserved air-conditioned berths, and travellers who were unsure about that tend to name it afterwards as the part they enjoyed most. If you would rather fly either leg, we will arrange it.

Journey Highlights

- **Discover** the two Delhis in a day — the walled Mughal city and Lutyens' capital — before boarding your first overnight train.
- **Enter** Lucknow, the city of the Nawabs, through the Rumi Darwaza to the Bara Imambara's vaulted hall and the ruined Residency.
- **Ride** Indian Railways twice by night and once by day, which is the quickest way to meet the country and its conversation.
- **Row** out onto the Ganges at Varanasi before sunrise, past the bathing ghats and the cremation ghats at Manikarnika and Harishchandra.
- **Watch** the evening aarti from the ghats, or take the afternoon out to Sarnath, where the Buddha gave his first teaching.
- **See** the Taj Mahal and Agra Fort, then Fatehpur Sikri on the road to Jaipur.
- **End** at Amer Fort, the City Palace and the Jantar Mantar, with Jaipur's bazaars for the last evening.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	**Delhi**	Arrival in the capital
Day 02	**Delhi**	Old and New Delhi, then the overnight train to Lucknow
Day 03	**Lucknow**	The Bara Imambara, Rumi Darwaza and the Residency
Day 04	**Lucknow to Varanasi**	By day train to the holy city

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 05	**Varanasi**	Dawn on the Ganges; the evening aarti
Day 06	**Varanasi**	A free morning, Sarnath if you wish, then the overnight train to Agra
Day 07	**Agra**	The Taj Mahal and Agra Fort
Day 08	**Agra to Jaipur**	Fatehpur Sikri en route to the pink city
Day 09	**Jaipur**	Amer Fort, City Palace and the Jantar Mantar
Day 10	**Jaipur to Delhi**	Return to Delhi for the onward flight

Day by Day

Expand all

> Some day descriptions are drafted from the published route and are awaiting the operator's confirmed copy.

Day 01 Delhi — Arrival in the Capital

Met on arrival and transferred to your hotel. Delhi has been inhabited since the sixth century BC and destroyed and rebuilt more times than anyone agrees on; New Delhi's wide avenues and monumental buildings sit beside an old city that is a maze of lanes, and the two make one of the more absorbing capitals in the world. The evening is free.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 02 Delhi — Two Cities, Then the Night Train

Overnight train — Delhi to Lucknow

The morning in Old Delhi, Shah Jahan's city of 1639: Raj Ghat and the Gandhi museum, a drive past the Red Fort and Chandni Chowk, and the Jama Masjid, one of the largest mosques in India. A rickshaw through the market is worth the noise. Check out at noon, and spend the afternoon in New Delhi — Qutub Minar and Humayun's Tomb, both UNESCO sites, India Gate, a drive past the Secretariat, Parliament and the presidential estate, and the Lakshminarayan Temple. In the evening, the transfer to the station for the overnight train to Lucknow.

Overnight aboard the train

Day 03 Lucknow — The City of the Nawabs

Arrive in the morning and go to your hotel. Lucknow is the capital of Uttar Pradesh and was the seat of the Nawabs of Awadh, whose taste is still the city's — gardens, baradaris, Imambaras, and a courtliness that survives in the language and the food. It was also a centre of the 1857 rebellion. The morning's tour takes in the Bara Imambara with its great unsupported vaulted hall and its labyrinth, the Chhota Imambara, the Rumi Darwaza, the Picture Gallery and clock tower, the ruined Residency and the Dilkusha Palace. The afternoon is free.

Overnight in Lucknow

Day 04 Varanasi — By Day Train to the Holy City

Day train — Lucknow to Varanasi

A free morning, then the afternoon train east to Varanasi — Benares, Kashi, the city of temples — which is among the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world and the spiritual capital of Hinduism. On arrival, the transfer to your hotel. The Ganges is a short walk; the first evening is best spent simply reaching it.

Overnight in Varanasi

Day 05 Varanasi — Dawn on the Ganges

Boat — Sunrise boat ride on the Ganges

Out on the river before sunrise, when the ghats fill with bathers and the light comes across the water from the far bank. The boat passes Manikarnika and Harishchandra, the two great cremation ghats, where the pyres burn day and night; in Hindu belief, to die here and be given to the river is release from the cycle of birth. The rest of the day is yours — rest, the lanes of the old city, or the afternoon out to Sarnath. In the evening, the Ganga aarti on the ghats: lamps, incense, bells and a crowd on the steps and on the water.

Overnight in Varanasi

Day 06 Varanasi to Agra — Sarnath, Then the Night Train

Overnight train — Varanasi to Agra

A free morning in Varanasi. If you did not go yesterday, Sarnath is a few kilometres north-east: the deer park where the Buddha gave his first teaching, with the Dhamek stupa, the Dharmarajika ruins and the museum that holds the Ashoka lion capital. Check out at noon; in the evening, the transfer to the railway station for the overnight train west to Agra.

Overnight aboard the train

Day 07 Agra — The Taj Mahal and the Fort

Arrive in the morning and transfer to your hotel in Agra. The Taj Mahal is the day: white marble on the bank of the Yamuna, built by Shah Jahan for Mumtaz Mahal between 1631 and 1648, and closed on Fridays. Then Agra Fort, a UNESCO site of the sixteenth century holding the Jahangir Palace, the Khas Mahal and the two audience halls. The afternoon is free, with the car at your disposal within the city — Agra is famous for marble inlay, and for handicrafts in marble, wood and metal.

Overnight in Agra

Day 08 Fatehpur Sikri — On the Road to Jaipur

Drive — about 240 km

Akbar's capital of the 1570s, abandoned within a generation and one of the most complete Mughal cities standing: the Jama Masjid, the marble tomb of Salim Chishti, the five-storey Panch Mahal, the Buland Darwaza, Birbal's house, Mariam-uz-Zamani's palace and the Ibadat Khana, where Akbar had the faiths debate in front of him. Then on to Jaipur, the pink city, painted for the Prince of Wales's visit in 1876 and never repainted. The rest of the day is yours to walk it.

Explore Jaipur →

Overnight in Jaipur

Day 09 Jaipur — Amer and the City

Amer Fort in the morning, the earlier capital, built by Raja Man Singh in red sandstone and marble around four courtyards — the Suraj Pol gate, the Sila Devi temple, the public and private audience halls, the Sheesh Mahal of mirrors, and the Sukh Niwas with its water-cooled breeze. Then the seven-storey City Palace, the Jantar Mantar observatory and the Hawa Mahal from the street, with its gardens. Jaipur is famous for shopping, and the afternoon is for it.

Explore Jaipur →

Overnight in Jaipur

Day 10 Jaipur to Delhi — Departure

Drive — about 270 km to Delhi airport

By road to Delhi and the airport in time for your return flight. No accommodation is included, as most long-haul departures leave after midnight; if yours does not, we will arrange a day room.

Explore Jaipur →

Departure

Practical notes

Getting there

Delhi's Indira Gandhi International (DEL) is the arrival and departure point.

Best time to visit

October to March. Varanasi is at its best in the cool, clear mornings of winter, and the plains are uncomfortable from April.

The trains

Two overnight journeys and one by day, in air-conditioned sleeper class with berths reserved in advance. They are part of the trip rather than a means to it — and we can substitute flights for either night if you prefer.

Pace

Active. Two nights on trains and two early mornings, balanced by free afternoons in Lucknow, Varanasi and Agra.